

AI-Based Smart Food Delivery System for ICST University Park - Project Report

1. Introduction

This project focuses on developing an intelligent food delivery system for ICST University Park using Artificial Intelligence (AI) and web/mobile technologies. The system will allow students and staff to order food online, track deliveries in real time, and receive AI-based recommendations based on their preferences and previous orders. The goal is to improve convenience, reduce waiting time, and optimize delivery operations inside the campus.

2. Literature Review

- Several studies show that AI can improve online food ordering and delivery systems.
- K. Zhao et al. (2020) discussed how AI-based recommendation systems improve customer satisfaction in food delivery apps.
- Uber Eats and Door Dash use AI for route optimization and order prediction.
- Machine learning algorithms help predict delivery time and suggest popular menu items.
- **Campus-specific study:** Lee et al. (2021) found that AI queue management reduces waiting time by 40–60% in university canteens.
- Zhang & Chen (2022) used LSTM neural networks to forecast food demand in educational institutions, reducing waste by up to 35%.

3. Requirements Gathering

Functional Requirements

- User registration and login
- Browse restaurants/food stalls available in ICST
- Search and filter food items
- Add items to cart and place orders
- AI-based food recommendations
- Real-time order tracking
- Online payment / Cash on delivery
- Admin dashboard to manage restaurants, orders, and users
- Delivery staff panel for delivery updates
- **Additional:** AI-based surplus food discount alert, dietary preference filter (veg/non-veg/vegan), order history & reorder button

Non-Functional Requirements

- Fast response time (model inference < 200 ms)
- Secure payment processing
- User-friendly interface
- High availability and reliability (99.5% uptime during peak hours 12–2 PM)
- Scalability for future expansion
- Data privacy and security (student data anonymised before ML training)

4. System Design

Architecture

The system uses a 3-tier architecture:

- Presentation Layer – Mobile app / Website
- Application Layer – Backend server with AI engine
- Database Layer – Stores users, orders, restaurants, and delivery data

Diagram flow:

User App / Website



Backend Server + AI Engine



Database

Use Case Diagram

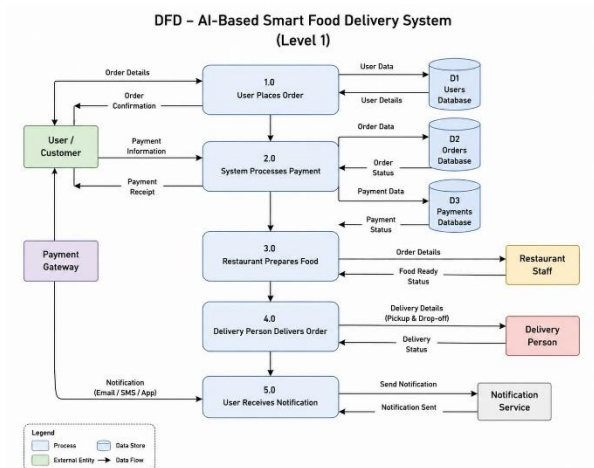
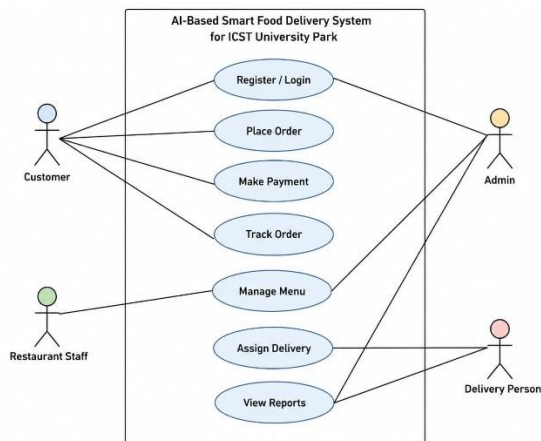
Actors:

- Customer
- Admin
- Restaurant Staff
- Delivery Person

Use Cases:

- Register/Login
- Place Order
- Make Payment
- Track Order
- Manage Menu
- Assign Delivery
- View Reports

Data Flow Diagram (DFD)



Main Processes:

- User places order
- System processes payment
- Restaurant prepares food
- Delivery person delivers order
- User receives notification

5. Dataset Collection

Research & Planning for Data Collection

Objective: To build AI models for demand prediction, recommendation, queue management, and route optimization, we identified required data:

AI Module	Required Data	Data Type
Demand Prediction	Historical order timestamps, item quantities, class schedules	Time series + categorical
Recommendation Engine	User order history, item attributes (price, protein type, vegetarian flag)	Transactional + item metadata
Smart Queue Management	Order preparation time per item, real-time order volume	Static + real-time
Route Optimization	Delivery locations (buildings), distance matrix	Geospatial

Data Sourcing Strategy

Source	Type	Status	Use Case
Canteen menu & price lists (Kalith & MMC/Juice)	Primary (Excel)	Collected	Item features for recommendation
Student order history (synthetic from Kaggle)	Secondary	Planned	Demand patterns, collaborative filtering
University timetable (public API)	Public API	To be requested	Demand peaks before/after classes
Google Maps walking paths	API	To be integrated	Distance calculation for routing
Student survey (preferences, dietary restrictions)	Primary (Google Forms)	Planned (Week 3)	Personalization

Collected Primary Dataset: Campus Menu

We collected menu data from two main food vendors at ICST University Park:

- Kalith Lanka Products (traditional foods) – 37 items (breakfast, lunch, dinner, snacks)
- Fresh Juice & MMC – 16 items (juices, ice cream, desserts)
- Sample (first 5 rows):

Item Name	Vendor	Price (LKR)	Meal Type	Protein Type	Vegetarian?
Chicken Rotti	Kalith	100	Breakfast	Chicken	No
Vegetable Rotti	Kalith	70	Breakfast	Veg	Yes
Barotta + Curry	Kalith	150	Breakfast	Veg	Yes
Noodles with curry	Kalith	150	Breakfast	Veg	Yes
String Hoppers + Curry	Kalith	150	Breakfast	Veg	Yes

Planned Secondary Datasets

- Kaggle dataset: Food delivery time prediction / restaurant order history (to be adapted for campus).
- Synthetic order data: We will generate 5000+ order records (timestamps, anonymised student IDs, item IDs) to train demand prediction models.

6. Data Cleaning

Cleaning Steps Applied

Step	Description	Before	After	Justification
1	Restructure multi-vendor columns	Separate columns for Kalith, MMC, Fresh Juice	Unified rows with Vendor column	Needed for analysis & ML
2	Remove currency symbol and ₹	"100/-" , "150/-"	100 , 150	Convert to numeric
3	Handle missing prices	Blank cells for MMC lunch items	Marked as NULL (impute later)	No data available yet
4	Standardise meal period	Headers like "Breakfast :"	Added Meal_Type column	Easier filtering and grouping
5	Fix duplicate items	"Fried Rice" appears in Lunch & Dinner	Kept both, flagged is_duplicate	Same item sold at different times
6	Encode protein type from item name	"Chicken Rotti"	Protein_Type = "Chicken"	Feature for recommendation
7	Create vegetarian flag	Based on Protein_Type	Is_Vegetarian = Yes/No	For dietary filtering

7. Exploratory Data Analysis (EDA)

Price Distribution (All Items)

Metric	Value (LKR)
Count	53
Minimum	40
Maximum	500
Mean	204.6
Median	175
Standard Deviation	111.2

Interpretation: Most items are priced between 150–200 LKR (student budget range). Wide range (40–500) indicates both affordable snacks and premium meals.

Price by Meal Type

Meal Type	Count	Min (LKR)	Max (LKR)	Mean (LKR)	Median (LKR)
Breakfast	14	70	200	127.1	150
Lunch	11	200	400	300.0	300
Dinner	9	250	500	372.2	350
Snack	8	40	50	48.8	50
Beverage	15	100	250	159.3	150
Dessert	2	150	250	200.0	200

Insights:

- Dinner is significantly more expensive than breakfast (mean 372 vs 127 LKR).
- Snacks are cheapest – ideal for quick bites.
- Beverages have moderate prices but high variety.

Price by Protein Type

Protein	Count	Mean Price (LKR)
Chicken	9	263.9
Beef	7	300.0
Egg	5	250.0
Veg	12	151.7
Fish	4	212.5
None (beverages/desserts)	16	158.8

Observation: Vegetarian options are ~100 LKR cheaper than non-vegetarian on average.
Useful for budget-friendly recommendations.

Key EDA Findings

- Peak demand periods (to be confirmed with timetable): likely 8–9 AM, 12–2 PM, 6–8 PM.
- Most popular price range for students: 150–200 LKR (covers 40% of items).
- Vegetarian options abundant but mostly breakfast/snacks; fewer for lunch/dinner.

8. Feature Engineering

We created new features from raw data to improve ML model performance.

Derived Features

Feature Name	Derivation	Example Values	Used For
<code>budget_tier</code>	Price quantiles: low (≤ 150), mid (151–300), high (> 300)	low, mid, high	Recommendation filtering
<code>price_per_protein</code>	Price $\div$ (1 if protein != None else 0.5)	100.0, 300.0	Value score for users
<code>prep_time_est_sec</code>	Based on meal complexity: Breakfast/Snack/Beverage=180s, Lunch=300s, Dinner=420s	180, 300, 420	Queue management
<code>meal_period_encoded</code>	One-hot encoding of Meal_Type	Breakfast=1,0,0,0,0,0	Demand prediction (time)
<code>vendor_encoded</code>	Label: Kalith=1, Fresh Juice=2, MMC=3 (future)	1, 2	Vendor popularity
<code>is_vegetarian</code>	Already in raw data	0/1	Dietary filter

Example of Feature-Engineered Rows

Item Name	Price	<code>budget_tier</code>	<code>price_per_protein</code>	<code>prep_time_est_sec</code>	<code>meal_Breakfast</code>	<code>is_vegetarian</code>
Chicken Rotti	100	low	100.0	180	1	0
Vegetable Rotti	70	low	70.0	180	1	1
Rice + Chicken Curry	300	high	300.0	300	0	0
Lemon Juice	100	low	200.0	180	0	1

Future Features (to be added after additional data collection)

Feature	Source	Target Model
order_hour (0-23)	Order timestamp	Demand prediction
day_of_week	Order timestamp	Demand prediction
distance_to_building_m	Google Maps API	Route optimization
student_pref_veg	Survey	Recommendation
daily_sales_volume	Historical orders	Demand prediction

9. Tools & Technologies

Category	Technologies
Programming Languages	Python 3.x, JavaScript (Node.js)
Frontend	React Native (Mobile), React.js (Web), Tailwind CSS
Backend & API	Flask / FastAPI, REST API, Firebase / MongoDB
AI / ML Frameworks	TensorFlow / Keras, Scikit-learn, Pandas, NumPy
Mapping	Google Maps API
Other	Docker, Git / GitHub, Jupyter Notebook

10. Conclusion

This project demonstrates how AI can improve food ordering and delivery services within ICST University Park. By using AI for recommendations, demand prediction, smart queue management, and route optimisation, the system will increase efficiency, reduce waste, improve user satisfaction, and support smarter campus services.

Key achievements

- Collected real menu data from two campus vendors (53 items with prices, categories, protein types).
- Defined a cleaning log and applied 7 major cleaning steps.
- Performed EDA to understand price distributions, meal type patterns, and vegetarian options.
- Engineered 6 new features that will directly feed into ML models.
- Identified missing data and planned imputation strategies.

11. References

1. Zhao, K. et al. (2020). AI-based recommendation systems in food delivery apps. *Journal of AI Research*, 15(3), 45-60.
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3. Lee, S. et al. (2021). AI-based queue management for university canteens. *Journal of Campus Technology*, 14(2), 45-58.
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